

cover story GUJARAT ELECTIONS

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SUPPORTING CAST: (L to R) BJP leaders Sushma Swaraj and Venkaiah Naidu (above) along with showbiz artiste Smriti Irani and MP Navjot Sidhu (below) trying to sell Brand Modi while the chief minister carries on a parallel blitzkrieg

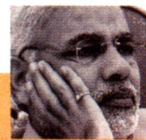


the party apparatus has already alienated a veteran like Keshubhai Patel, and the party may suffer a bit from the Patel rap in the Saurashtra region. (Modi underplays the rebellion, and will tell you that there are only three rebels in the fray). The RSS, too, is apparently not comfortable with the best-selling mythology of the one who was once just a *swayamsevak*, even though his core personality is molded by the *shakha* and he never misses an opportunity to attribute his "magic" to the Sangh experience. Ask him about the personality cult—though he has not yet migrated to the cardboard—he is quick to demystify himself: "My RSS background has given me a great sense of responsibility." Still, when there is a leader with a capital L in the vanguard, no one else has to take the blame if something goes terribly wrong. And if everything goes right—that is what Modi hopes—no one else will get any credit either. The Modi cult—built on the right mix of kitsch, fear and power—is already overwhelming. He multiplies even in his absence. When the Great Helmsman is not there, the candidates

will be blessed by volunteers in reassuring Modi masks.

The mask of Modi, it seems, has made the apparatchiks of the party almost redundant. An evening in the party office in Ahmedabad is less active than the kiosks outside selling Modi souvenirs. Where are the customary constituency statistics and those computer printouts on strategies and tactics the backroom brains usually share with the media? (All the data are stored in Modi's computer, the man himself will inform you later.) Arun Jaitley, who is officially in charge of the campaign, has his own sociology ready for making sense of the Modi effect. He admits, there has been no other leader since Vajpayee who has grown larger than the party. "He is like the Amitabh Bachchan of the '70s, the angry young man who cannot afford to be

a romantic hero. He defies the "Gujarati stereotype" of the wimp—or the weakling. Doesn't it mean that the traditional party structure has nothing much to contribute as this one big idea dominates the entire battlefield? Jaitley doesn't think the rage of the Modi cult will outlive the party. "He is a transient figure. The party won't be Modi." Beyond the party office, ardent Modi fans are praying for the permanence of the Modi model in leadership as well as development. "He is a conviction politician, we need him. He is prime minister material, but when that day comes, it will be our loss," rhapsodises Paru M. Jayakrishna, president of the Gujarat Chamber of Commerce & Industry and the matriarch of one of Ahmedabad's oldest business families. "He is the CEO of Gujarat and a great



The Modi who looms over Gujarat 2007 is larger, stronger and overpowering

